burying the dead instead of cremation—meant that, by the time of Independence, some caste scholars had begun referring to them as a ‘caste-sect’. Others, like M.N. Srinivas, regarded the Lingayats as a ‘status-honour’ group linked with the process of ‘Sanskritisation’.[15] It was this long-standing debate that Congress Chief Minister Siddaramaiah had waded into with his minority-status proposal in 2018.

These two traditionally powerful caste groups, Lingayats and Vokkaligas, virtually controlled state politics between 1956 and 1972[16]—the L–V caste equation that powered the Congress’s political hold over Karnataka until the mid-1970s. As political scientist James Manor summed up, ‘This system worked well so that the period between 1956 and the early 1970s can be seen as an era of Lingayat raj (with Vokkaliga support) in which the dominant groups had rather smooth sailing.’[17]

The political dominance of these castes was so pronounced that, in the 1952–1972 period, Lingayats accounted for an average of 31 per cent of the Karnataka assembly’s legislators (despite being only 15.5 per cent of the population at the time). Vokkaligas made up an average of 27.9 per cent of legislators (despite being 12.98 per cent of the population then).[18] In other words, for several decades, every second Karnataka legislator belonged to one of these two castes. This is also reflected in the choice of chief ministers. Before the 1956 reorganisation, two of Mysore state’s first three chief ministers were Vokkaligas (1947–1956). After the reorganisation, the first four chief ministers were all Lingayats (1956–1971). Thereafter, leaders from other caste groups started occupying the seat of power in Bengaluru as new caste coalitions began to challenge the traditional structures of power. But Lingayat leaders still made up 45 per cent (nine of twenty) of all state chief ministers between 1956 and 2021 (see Table 15.1).

After Lingayat regional satrap S. Nijalingappa (chief minister in 1956–1958 and then 1962–1968) broke away from the Congress in the great split of 1969—between Indira Gandhi and the Old Guard (called the ‘Syndicate’)—state Congress leaders wove together a new rainbow caste coalition. Chief Minister Devaraj Urs in 1972 sought to break the stranglehold of the Lingayats and the Vokkaligas